

Sashaying among the haute couture crowd at weekly label launches and boutique parties, sharing canapés the size of fingernails and washing them away with enough champagne to drown *Ab Fab* soak Patsy Stone, I was afraid I would be judged if I couldn't fire a brand name back when asked, 'Who are you wearing?'

That's such a fashion foible – *who*, not *what*, are you wearing.

And so I came to acquire my collection of several vintage European designer handbags, more than 50 pairs of shoes, about a kilogram of costume jewellery, 15 pairs of jeans, 12 winter coats, 40 dresses, 25 bras, several sets of shapewear that could crush a small truck with their combined pressure, enough scarves to cloak a football team cheer squad and much, much more.

I bought myself a \$1700 Louis Vuitton tote bag on my 30th birthday, reasoning that the milestone called for a splurge. I had no excuse for the rest of the excess – I was a fashionista with an insatiable urge. I have since sold the tote bag, along with many other bags, shoes and clothes.

Hitting rock bottom

My path back to more fertile financial ground – to grow a nest egg, the deposit for my first home – called for the sort of sacrifice and self-control that I'd lost my grip on.

The Pocket Money Savings Plan, which I outlined in the introduction, was devised with the help of my father, journalist and author Danny Power, after I hit rock bottom – financially and mentally – in 2015. By that point, buying a property was front of my mind, but first I needed the debt collectors to stop calling.

In my five-year tenure as a fashion editor, I'd raked up around \$14,000 in credit card debt, mainly on clothes and socialising, which had accumulated in two instalments, each on a card with a \$7000 limit. I didn't have any savings, and I was living hand to mouth, paycheque to paycheque.

As I mentioned in the introduction, before I'd started in fashion I had undergone treatment for an illness in my mid-20s – an ovarian tumour – which was an unexpected expense that ran into five figures. But instead of using that as a lesson that life can spin on a high heel, and that it pays to be prepared, I'd thrown myself into more partying and purchasing.